

# Aby Rosen's 190 Bowery Sale: Liquidity, Not Nostalgia, Drives the Offer

The sale of a fully leased trophy asset reveals more about sponsor timing than market confidence.

The most telling number in Aby Rosen's decision to sell 190 Bowery is not the price. It is the timing. Rosen bought the six-story, 33,000-square-foot former Germania Bank building for \$55 million in 2015, when it was vacant and famously spooky. He spent the next decade restoring its Beaux Arts facade, modernizing its systems, and leasing the office floors to Industrious at a \$95 per square foot asking rent.

The building is now 100% leased. The graffiti remains. The mystery is gone. Rosen is not selling because he has lost faith in the asset. He is selling because the repositioning is complete, the income stream is stabilized, and the market is finally producing bids at a basis that lets him monetize a decade of work into liquidity. That liquidity has a purpose. RFR has been an active seller in recent years.

The firm has 281 Park Avenue South in contract at roughly \$2,000 per square foot. It has unloaded several other properties. Rosen still holds the Seagram Building, 477 Madison Avenue, and 15 State Street. The pattern is not distress. It is portfolio management by a sponsor who understands that public and private market liquidity windows do not stay open forever.

The sale of 190 Bowery is a capital markets signal, not a real estate one. It tells us that the bid for fully leased, well-located, repositioned office assets in New York has returned to a level where sponsors can exit with a clear story and a defensible basis.

It also tells us that sponsors who bought at the bottom of the last cycle are now harvesting gains into a market that still demands proof of income before it writes a check. Who benefits from this transaction? The buyer gets a stabilized asset with a strong tenant, a proven sponsor, and a basis that reflects the repositioning, not the original purchase.

The seller gets liquidity to redeploy into higher-return opportunities or to strengthen the balance sheet. The broker, Avison Young's James Nelson, gets another data point that the office market is not frozen, just selective. Who is exposed? Any owner of a similar asset that has not yet completed its repositioning. The market is rewarding finished stories, not works in progress.

The gap between stabilized and unstabilized office assets is widening, and the cost of carrying a vacant or partially leased building through a refinancing is becoming prohibitive. The next phase of the market will not be defined by who owns the best story. It will be defined by who controls the cheapest capital and the most patient timeline. Rosen is selling because he has both.



The buyer will need to prove they do too.

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Light Tower Group is a commercial real estate capital advisory firm helping owners, developers, and investors structure and source debt, preferred equity, joint venture equity, and other institutional capital solutions.

We work across acquisitions, refinancings, recapitalizations, and development projects, with a focus on clear strategy, credible execution, and capital that fits the deal.

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